PHYSICALLY IMPOSSIBLE

The Keisha Story

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278 Leslie Lane
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mushroomcloudpress@gmail.com
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Narrator: It's a spring Saturday morning as Keisha slowly stirs from her night's sleep. The birds are aflutter and the flowers are in bloom as they were the day before, and as they'd be the day after. But while the world would remain largely the same, Keisha's life would never be the same.

(Keisha wakes up and yawns, not yet aware of what has happened to her overnight.)

Narrator: She tries to pull off her blanket, but she can't. She tries to open the window to see the birds aflutter and the flowers in bloom, but she can't. What could the problem be?

Keisha: Well, this is very peculiar.

Narrator: Very peculiar indeed. Keisha senses something is wrong, but she can't put her finger on what. In fact, it doesn't seem as if she has a finger to put on anything, for that matter. She can't even manage to scratch her head and wonder.

Keisha: What could be wrong?

(Keisha is pondering when she glances down and realizes the problem.)

Narrator: And that's when it hits her.

Keisha: Why, I don't have any arms! What am I going to do?

Narrator: What indeed. And this is where Keisha's fascinating story begins, a story we hear far too rarely: how a perpetual optimist awakens to discover she has lost both of her arms. *(Singing)* Keisha, she's so thoughtful, Keisha, she's got charm. Keisha, the optimistic girl with no arms

Narrator: It's now Monday morning, and Keisha is getting ready for her first day of school. Word gets around fast in Smalltown, Nebraska, and the news of Keisha's condition has spread. This week is a big week for Keisha. She has an English paper due Friday, the same day as

the big state championship soccer match and the Spring Dance. Smalltown High is very concerned about all of this.

Mr. Cohen: How is Keisha going to finish her English paper without any arms? I don't have it in me to fail someone as thoughtful and optimistic as she is.

Coach: How is Keisha gonna play in the game Friday night? This is our first chance to win States, and now our all-state goalie has no arms! She's led this team here, but I can't let her play.

Lindsay: Tom, are you really taking Keisha to the Spring Dance?

Tom: I don't know, Lindsay. I mean, I really like her, but-

Lindsay: *(Grabbing Tom's face)* Tom, look at me. She's a no-armed freak! Do you know what she'd do for your reputation?

Tom: Well… I… Yeah, I guess you're right.

Narrator: Yes, it's going to be a difficult week for Keisha, a week she won't soon forget. The trouble starts in Mr. Cohen's English class.

Mr. Cohen: Keisha, you didn't really participate at all in class today. You usually always have something very thoughtful to contribute to the class.

Keisha: I'm sorry, Mr. Cohen. I really wanted to, but you never called on me.

Mr. Cohen: Well maybe if you raised your- *(Realizes what he's about to say)* never mind that. I just wanted to tell you that I talked to the English chairman, and I'm not allowed to give you any preferential treatment, regardless of your… um… capabilities. So you'll still have to turn in your paper this Friday.

Keisha: I understand, Mr. Cohen. I don't want to be treated any differently now than I was before.

Mr. Cohen: Don't get me wrong, I really fought for you, but the chairman tends to be very heavy-handed- ugh, I'm sorry, Keisha, I mean there's really nothing I can do; he's twisting my arm on this one- dammit, you know what I'm trying to say.

Narrator: It looks like Keisha's not going to get any slack on her English paper. And soccer practice won't be any better.

Lindsay: Keisha? What are you doing here? You don't play soccer.

Keisha: What do you mean? I'm the goalie. I've been the goalie all year.

Lindsay: Oh, sorry, two-armed Keisha played goalie. No-armed Keisha has no place on this team.

Keisha: You're the most hurtful person I've ever met, Lindsay. How can you judge me like that? I'm still the same Keisha.

Lindsay: Psh, please. You're a couple of limbs short of being the same Keisha. We'd be better off having Nelson Mandela in goal.

Keisha: I… wait, I don't get it.

Lindsay: It doesn't matter whether you get it or not, you don't have any arms. Tell you what, Keisha, raise your hand if you think you can still play goalie.

Keisha: I… you… bitch…

Lindsay: My, we don't have a very optimistic outlook, now do we? Coach, did you hear that? Keisha doesn't think she can still play goalie.

Coach: Keisha, I can't discriminate against you because of your… um… condition, but if you don't have faith and optimism in yourself, then I can't in good conscience let you play.

Keisha: Coach, you can't do this to me. I'm an all-state goalie. You can't take this away from me.

Lindsay: Oh, sorry, Keisha, but his hands are tied. You're just not the same Keisha.

Keisha: You know what? Fine. *(Keisha storms off)*

Lindsay: Freak.

Narrator: Things are bad for Keisha, real bad. She had never been faced with such harsh discrimination before. And with nowhere to turn, Keisha did the only thing she could think of: she sat down on the curb and started to cry.

Heroin Joe: Keisha, what's the matter?

Keisha: Oh, hey Heroin Joe. It's nothing. Don't worry about it.

Heroin Joe: You know you can talk to me about anything. Come on, tell me.

Keisha: Well, ever since I lost my arms, people have been treating me as if I was a different person. No one thinks I'm thoughtful or optimistic anymore. They don't see Keisha, they just see a no-armed freak.

Heroin Joe: Well, do you still feel thoughtful and optimistic?

Keisha: I… I don't know anymore.

Heroin Joe: Keisha, not many people know this, but before I was known as Heroin Joe, I was world-renowned for my studies on the true effects of illegal drugs on people. But then there was a shortage of willing research participants, so I had to test the heroin on the one person who would allow it: myself. I developed an addiction, and now I'm Heroin Joe.

Keisha: That's awful, Joe, but I don't see what this has to do with me.

Heroin Joe: I'm getting to that. When you make the jump from respected scientist to heroin addict, people begin to look at you differently. Because how can a drug addict still have a brilliant mind? But between you and me, I still sneak into my old lab and do experiments, and I just got some work published under the name Chester A. Arthur.

Keisha: Your pseudonym is the name of a former president?

Heroin Joe: Never mind the pseudonym. The point is that I don't let people tell me who I am. You say you're still the same Keisha, then be the same thoughtful, optimistic Keisha.

Keisha: Yeah, but what if I don't feel very optimistic about people right now?

Heroin Joe: Don’t worry about people, Keisha. There’s some bad ones, but the good ones will do the right thing in the end.

(Tom enters, looking a slightly nervous, but not in a way that shows any nerves about Keisha’s lack of arms.)

Tom: Hey, Keisha, where were you today? I didn’t get to see you at school.

Keisha: Oh, hey Tom, sorry. It’s been a pretty weird day for me.

Tom: So… you want to go to the Spring Dance with me Friday?

Keisha: Sure, I’d love to.

Tom: Great, it’s gonna be a blast.

(Tom exits, leaving only Keisha and Heroin Joe.)

Heroin Joe: See? Just give people a chance, and they’ll do the right thing.

Keisha: Thanks, Heroin Joe.

Heroin Joe: Anytime, Keisha. Now if you’ll excuse me, I have to go pass out in that dumpster.

Narrator: That pep talk from Joe was exactly what Keisha needed. She had the confidence to be Keisha again, and that meant winning back her position as goalie of the soccer team. Tuesday’s soccer practice was the beginning of a fresh start for her.

Keisha: Coach, I’m the goalie that got us to the championship game, and I’m the goalie that’s the best bet to win States. I’m still Keisha, just give me a chance to prove it.

Coach: Hmm, well you definitely seem to have regained your optimism since yesterday. Alright, let’s give you a workout just to be sure. Lindsay, come here please.

Lindsay: What’s up, Coach? *(Noticing Keisha)* Ew, what’s that doing back here?

Keisha: My name is Keisha, and I’m the Smalltown High starting goalie.

Coach: Lindsay, I'm gonna set up a few balls, just take some shots at Keisha, give her a workout.

Lindsay: Will do, Coach. (*Under her breath, to Keisha)* Let's see what you can do, freak.

(Keisha prepares for the shot. Lindsay shoots at the top corner of the net, but Keisha manages to jump and deflect the shot with her head. Lindsay is stunned and Keisha dizzy, but both shake themselves out of it. Lindsay tries another shot high with the same result. Finally, Lindsay kicks the ball with all her might, and Keisha kicks the ball right back, hitting Lindsay in the face.)

Lindsay: Ow, my nose! I think it's broken.

Coach: Yep, that's our Keisha. And she's ready.

Lindsay: Will someone help me?

Keisha: You know I'm ready.

Lindsay: I hate you all. (*Lindsay runs off, clutching her nose)*

Coach: Keisha, I want to work with you all day, every day this week. You're definitely ready to play, but we need to be sure that you're ready to win.

Keisha: I'd love to Coach, but Mr. Cohen already said there's no way I can get out of doing my English paper by Friday.

(Flashback to Heroin Joe.)

Heroin Joe: Just give people a chance, and they'll do the right thing.

(End Flashback.)

Keisha: You know what, I think I'll go ask Mr. Cohen again.

Narrator: Keisha sure hopes Heroin Joe knew what he was talking about, or there was no chance she'd get to play. But fortunately for her, Heroin Joe was just as wise as he was intelligent.

Keisha: Mr. Cohen, can I talk to you for a minute?

Mr. Cohen: Yes, Keisha, I was meaning to talk to you. Shut the door, would you? *(Beat)* Actually, I'll get it.

Keisha: *(Closing the door with her foot)* It's ok, Mr. Cohen, I can handle it. What did you want to talk to me about?

Mr. Cohen: Keisha, your coach called and told me that you were still playing goalie this Friday. Is this true?

Keisha: Yes, but I won't have time to write your paper and prepare for the game.

Mr. Cohen: That's what I wanted to talk to you about. Keisha, I'll be blunt. Your story is remarkable, and if you win this game Friday, it will be the stuff that books get written about. I can see it now: Girl overcomes lack of arms to lead team to victory. It's Physically Impossible: The Keisha Story. You win that game, you let me write your story, you get an A on your paper.

Keisha: Don't worry Mr. Cohen, we'll win. But what about the chairman?

Mr. Cohen: Keisha, if I can write this book, you won't see me teaching anymore. It'll be all book tours and a villa in the wine country from here on out.

Narrator: And just like that, everything seems to be going Keisha's way. After spending the rest of the week practicing, it was time for the moment of truth: the state championship game.

Chip: Hello, and this is Chip Lafferty coming to you with live coverage of this year's Nebraska Girl's Soccer High School Championship. With me as always is my color commentator, Heroin Joe.

Heroin Joe: Good to be here, Chip. The story of tonight's match has been the goalkeeping. After 90 minutes of regulation and an overtime period, the score is still tied 0-0.

Chip: As per Nebraska State soccer rules, we now go to a sudden death penalty shootout. Smalltown High came into the season with the better record and will shoot first. Smalltown's best scorer, Lindsay, will step up to take the shot, broken nose and all.

(Lindsay shoots at the top corner of the net. The ball gets past the outstretched arms of the opposing goalie.)

Chip: And she scores! Smalltown now leads 1-0 in the shootout.

Heroin Joe: It's all up to Keisha now. If she stops this shot, the game is over and Smalltown wins.

Chip: Right you are, Joe. The small town of Smalltown's hopes are riding on the thoughtful, optimistic girl with no arms.

Coach: *(To himself)* Come on, Keisha, you've been working all week for this. You can do this.

Mr. Cohen: *(To himself)* Come on, Keisha, this is the only way I can pass you. You have to do this.

Keisha: *(Sighs and prepares for the shot)* I can do this.

(The opposing player shoots at the same spot Lindsay did at practice, and once again, Keisha manages to deflect the ball with her head.)

Coach: Yes!

Keisha: *(Still dizzy from the save)* I did it!

Mr. Cohen: Hello, wine country.

Chip: And she's done it! Keisha stops the penalty shot to preserve the shutout and the state championship! She is truly the most valuable player of this game, and a heroine to all of Smalltown.

Heroin Joe: Heroin? Where'd you see heroin?

Chip: Not the drug, you deadbeat, it's a female hero. And who let a drug addict be my color commentator anyway?

Heroin Joe: Hey, I know my girl's high school soccer. And you can't talk to me like that, I'm Chester A. Arthur.

Narrator: And such ends Keisha's long week and all of its twists and turns. Later tonight, Tom will escort Keisha to the Spring Dance, he in a tuxedo and she in a sleeveless dress. And no one will make a joke about this, because everyone knows she's still the same old Keisha. *(Singing)* Keisha, she's so thoughtful, Keisha, she's got charm. Keisha, the optimistic girl with no arms.